

SOVEREIGN

Govern Your Attention

Full Project Specification

Philosophy · Architecture · Deployment

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Reclaim the right to be unreachable.

This is not for those who hunger for connection.

It is for those who have forgotten what it feels like to be without it.

PART I: THE MANIFESTO

Sovereign: A Manifesto for Attention

There is a moment most of us have lived but rarely name.

You are sitting across from someone you love. They are speaking. And your hand, almost without your permission, reaches for your phone.

Not because anything important happened. Not because you were bored. But because the habit is deeper than the intention now. The device has become the default state. Presence has become an effort.

This is not an accident.

The Agreement You Never Signed

Somewhere in the last decade, a quiet agreement was made on your behalf.

The agreement said: you will be available. Always. To everyone. Instantly.

You didn't sign it. But you accepted it, because everyone did. Because the alternative felt like isolation. Because the tools that connected you to the people you love also connected you to everything else, and separating them seemed impossible.

The algorithm understood this before you did. It was designed to. Your attention, your most finite and most personal resource, became a commodity. Bought and sold in milliseconds. Packaged and delivered to advertisers while you scrolled, refreshed, checked, and scrolled again.

They called it connection. It was an extraction.

What Sovereign Is Not

We are not anti-technology.

We are not asking you to move to a cabin, abandon your WhatsApp, or explain to your mother why she can't reach you anymore.

We understand that digital infrastructure is real infrastructure. That your bank lives in an app. That your work runs on notifications. That the people you love are on platforms you didn't choose but can't leave.

We are not fighting that world. We are learning to govern our place in it.

Sovereign is not for those who hunger for connection. It is for those who have forgotten what it feels like to be without it.

The Right to Be Unreachable

| ***You have the right to be unreachable.***

Not forever. Not from everyone. But on your terms. At your pace. By your choice.

The right to finish a meal without an interruption that wasn't urgent. The right to wake up slowly, without the world's demands already waiting on your nightstand. The right to be bored, genuinely and productively bored, and let your mind wander somewhere the algorithm can't follow.

These are not luxuries. They are the conditions of a human life.

What Sovereign Is

Sovereign is a framework. An open ecosystem. A community.

It is a middleware layer between you and your digital world, a quiet filter that learns what truly matters to you and lets only that through. Everything else waits. The important things still reach you. On a calm device. In your own time.

It is self-hosted for those who want full control. It is managed for those who simply want peace. It is open source because no company should own the infrastructure of your attention.

And it is a community of people rebuilding the same thing: the right to govern themselves.

Who This Is For

You don't need to be exhausted to join.

You don't need to have already decided.

You only need to have felt, at least once, that your phone was living your life slightly faster than you were.

That feeling is the beginning.

Sovereign. Govern your attention.

PART II: THE VOCABULARY

Sovereign uses a deliberate language. Every term was chosen because it reinforces the philosophy. Use these consistently across all documentation, community communication, and interfaces.

Term	Definition
The Council	Your curated list of people whose messages always reach you. Small by design. Not your contacts list, but your actual council.
The Decrees	Your user-defined rules. The rulebook you write for your own life. IF [condition] THEN [action].
The Advisor	The AI layer. Learns your behavioral patterns over time to refine what reaches you.
The Vault	Everything that didn't reach you. Held, never deleted. Waiting for your attention on your schedule.
The Chronicle	Your history with Sovereign. An honest record of what was held and what passed through.
The Realm	Your personal Sovereign instance. Your configuration, your data, your rules.
The Commonwealth	The Sovereign community. People running their own Realms, sharing Decrees and insights.
The Territory	Your dumb phone. The calm device that is your primary interface with the world.

PART III: THE ARCHITECTURE

Sovereign is a personal communication router. Messages enter from multiple platforms, pass through an urgency evaluation engine, and either reach you immediately via SMS on your dumb phone, or wait in the Vault until you choose to engage.

```
LAYER 1 → Ingestion      : messages enter from all platforms
LAYER 2 → Urgency Engine : messages are evaluated
LAYER 3 → Delivery       : urgent messages reach your dumb phone
LAYER 4 → Reply Routing  : you respond from anywhere
LAYER 5 → The Advisor    : the system learns you
LAYER 6 → The Interface  : you govern everything
LAYER 7 → Deployment    : the world runs it
```

Layer 1: Ingestion

The ingestion layer is a set of platform connectors. Each one listens to a specific platform and normalizes incoming messages into a single internal format. Sovereign's core never knows or cares which platform sent a message.

Normalized Message Format

```
{ "id": "uuid", "timestamp": "ISO8601", "platform": "whatsapp", "sender": {
  "id": "platform_user_id", "name": "Mamá", "phone": "+573001234567" },
  "content": { "type": "text", "body": "Lláname cuando puedas" }, "group":
  null, "metadata": {}}
```

Platform Connectors

Platform	Method	Difficulty	Risk
Telegram	Official Bot API	Easy	None
Email	IMAP/SMTP	Easy	None
WhatsApp	mautrix-whatsapp bridge	Medium	Low-Medium (personal use)
Facebook Messenger	Meta Business API	Medium	Approval required
Instagram DM	Unofficial	Hard	High (V2 feature)
SMS	Twilio / GSM modem	Easy	None

WhatsApp Decision: mautrix-whatsapp

Sovereign uses mautrix-whatsapp over Baileys for one critical reason: it emulates human web client behavior rather than bot behavior, resulting in substantially lower ban risk for personal use.

Key constraints to design around:

- The phone must connect to the internet once every 14 days or the bridge session expires. Sovereign reminds you 3 days before.
- Messages are in plaintext inside the bridge server. Self-hosting is non-negotiable for privacy. The managed cloud tier runs one isolated bridge instance per user.

Connector Architecture

Each connector is an independent module. New platforms can be added by the community without touching Sovereign core logic.

```
sovereign/  connectors/  whatsapp/  telegram/  instagram/  email/  sms/
core/      engine/      delivery/  advisor/  interface/
```

Layer 2: The Urgency Engine

The heart of Sovereign. Every incoming message is evaluated through three tiers in sequence. If any tier declares urgency, the message passes through immediately.

```
MESSAGE RECEIVED
sender on my VIP list? [ ] | TIER 1: THE COUNCIL | → Is this
urgent) [ ] | TIER 2: THE DECREES | → Does this match my
rules? [ ] | TIER 3:
THE ADVISOR | → Does AI pattern suggest urgency? [ ] |
(not urgent)MESSAGE HELD IN VAULT
```

Tier 1: The Council

A curated list of people whose messages always pass through. Small by design, so Sovereign nudges users to keep this under 10 people. Each Council member can have per-channel configuration and quiet hours override settings.

Tier 2: The Decrees

User-defined rules with full condition flexibility:

Condition Type	Example
Keyword	Message contains 'emergency', 'hospital', 'urgent'
Sender pattern	From any number with country code +243
Platform	From email only; ignore all WhatsApp group messages
Time context	Any message while calendar shows 'Deep Work'
Message type	Voice notes from Council members always urgent
Frequency	Same sender messages 3+ times within 10 minutes

Default Decree set shipped with every new Sovereign instance:

- Keywords: 'emergency', 'urgent', 'hospital', 'accident', 'llámame', 'ayuda', 'please call'
- Frequency: 3 messages from same sender within 10 minutes
- Groups: no group messages pass through by default (ever)
- Email: only Council addresses pass through
- Voice notes: held, transcribed, evaluated for keywords

Tier 3: The Advisor

The AI layer. Learns behavioral patterns from your responses, never from message content. Outputs a confidence score with explanation, and can suggest Council promotions or Decree refinements. See Layer 5 for full Advisor specification.

Core Guardrail

Sovereign never silently drops a message. Every message either passes through or is held in the Vault. Nothing is deleted. Nothing is lost.

Layer 3: The Delivery Layer

Where the urgent message travels from Sovereign to your dumb phone via SMS. Simple, intentional, calm.

SMS Format

Every SMS follows a compressed, contextual format designed for small screens and 160-character limits:

```
[WA] Mamá: Llámame cuando puedas, es importante. ¿Estás bien?[TG] Carlos:
Emergency at the office, need you now. Call me.[WA] Mamá: 🎤 Voice note (47s) ·
Tier 1 pass[WA] Carlos: ⚡ 4 messages in 8 min
```

Format rules: platform tag first, sender name as configured in Sovereign, content truncated at 140 characters. Frequency escalations show the ⚡ symbol with count and timeframe.

SMS Gateway Options

Provider	Best For	Cost
Twilio	Managed cloud tier	Per message
Vonage	Managed cloud tier	Per message
Local carrier API	Self-hosted, technical users	Local plan
USB GSM modem + SIM	Full sovereignty, home server	One-time hardware + SIM

Quiet Hours

The delivery layer enforces quiet hours independently from the urgency engine. During quiet hours, urgent messages are held at delivery, not dropped. Council members with override permission still reach you. A threshold override triggers if 5+ urgent messages arrive within 30 minutes from any source.

Privacy Guarantee

Your dumb phone number is never exposed to any originating platform. WhatsApp sees your WhatsApp number. Sovereign sees both. Nobody else does.

Layer 4: Reply Routing

The layer that closes the loop. An SMS reply from your dumb phone is received by Sovereign, matched to the correct originating conversation, and routed back to the platform, invisibly and instantly.

Session Mapping

Every urgent message delivery creates a session record with a 15-minute reply window. During that window, any SMS from your dumb phone is automatically matched to that conversation. After the window expires, conversation reference commands are used:

```
r [message]          → reply to most recent urgent messenger mama [message]      →  
reply to last message from contact namer 2 [message]      → reply to 2nd most  
recent held messagelist          → Sovereign SMS back numbered list of held  
messagesread 3          → Sovereign SMS back content of held message #3status  
→ Sovereign replies with vault summary
```

Vault Status via SMS

Typing 'status' from your dumb phone returns:

```
SOVEREIGN 19:47Held: 12 messagesUrgent today: 3Last: Carlos (TG) 18:30Council: all  
quietNext check window: 20:00
```

Invisibility Principle

Recipients never know their message was filtered, held, or routed through Sovereign. From your mother's perspective on WhatsApp: she sent a message, you replied. Normal conversation. Sovereign is invisible infrastructure.

Read receipts on WhatsApp only trigger when you genuinely access the message, not when Sovereign processes it. Sovereign never pretends you read something you haven't.

Layer 5: The Advisor

The Advisor makes Sovereign personal. It learns your definition of urgency from your behavior, never from message content, and refines the engine over time.

The Signal

The Advisor watches one thing: what you do after Sovereign makes a decision.

```
DECISION: PASS (urgent)      ↓Did you reply within 10 minutes? YES → signal:
correct pass ✓ NO → signal: false positive ✗DECISION: HOLD (not urgent)
↓Did you retrieve it within 1 hour of opening vault? YES → signal: false negative
✗ NO → signal: correct hold ✓
```

Maturity Levels

Level	Name	When	Behavior
0	Silent	Weeks 1-2	Observing only. No interventions.
1	Suggesting	Weeks 3-4	Surfacing first patterns. Your decision always.
2	Advising	Month 2+	Regular recommendations with full data shown.
3	Refining	Month 4+	Auto-weight adjustment (opt-in only).
4	Sovereign	Month 6+	Filter fully personalized. Near-zero false signals.

Privacy Architecture

What the Advisor stores: sender identifier (hashed), timestamp, Sovereign decision, tier triggered, your response time, platform identifier.

What the Advisor never stores: message content, your reply content, contact names in plaintext, anything that could reconstruct a conversation.

The behavioral model is strictly per-user and never pooled. Your patterns never train anyone else's Advisor. This is the inverse of how every major platform operates.

Community Insights

Individual Advisors never pool data. But anonymized aggregate patterns, opt-in only, feed back into better default Decrees for new users. The community's collective experience improves the starting point for everyone who comes after.

The Reset

You can reset the Advisor to zero at any time, no questions asked. You own the model. Sovereign has no interest in keeping it.

Layer 6: The Interface

The interface is not your primary interaction with Sovereign. Your dumb phone is. The interface is where you govern, occasionally and thoughtfully, with intention. A study, not a cockpit.

The Five Rooms

Room	Purpose	Frequency of Visit
The Vault	Everything held. Review and reply on your schedule.	Daily or as needed
The Council	Your VIP list. Add, remove, configure per-member settings.	Rarely, when relationships change
The Decrees	Your rules. Keyword sets, patterns, quiet hours.	Weekly at first, then rarely
The Advisor	Suggestions from your behavioral patterns. One at a time.	Weekly
The Chronicle	Your history. Honest numbers. No gamification.	Weekly

Design Principles

- No red notification badges anywhere in the interface
- No unread counts displayed in bold to create anxiety
- No color used to signal urgency
- Typography: serif headings for weight and permanence
- Two colors maximum: dark and one accent
- No animations except deliberate room transitions
- No sounds, ever
- Mobile-first but never mobile-addictive

Access Model

The interface is not an app on your phone. It is browser-only, accessed at home on your local network (self-hosted) or via a private URL (managed cloud). It will never be on the App Store. That friction is a feature.

Onboarding

The first screen a new user sees:

```
Welcome to Sovereign. Before we begin, one question: Who are the people whose
message should always reach you, no matter what, no matter when? Take your time.
This list matters. [ Begin building your Council ]
```

No feature tour. No tooltip overlays. No progress bars. One question, answered honestly.

Layer 7: Deployment

Three Deployment Paths

Path	Who	Cost	Control
A. Self-Hosted	Technical users	Free	Full sovereignty
B. Managed Cloud	Anyone	€4.90/month	Zero maintenance
C. Hybrid	Power users	Partial fee	Local data, cloud infra

Path A: Self-Hosted

The entire stack in one command:

```
git clone https://github.com/sovereign-stack/sovereign cd sovereign cp .env.example .env# Edit .env with your settings docker compose up -d
```

Hardware Option	Cost	Best For
VPS (2GB RAM, 20GB SSD)	~€5/month	Most self-hosted users
Home server / old laptop	One-time	Tech enthusiasts
Raspberry Pi 4 + USB GSM modem + SIM	~€60 one-time	Full sovereignty purists

Path B: Managed Cloud

Pricing philosophy: two tiers, honest prices, no dark patterns.

```
FREE TIER · Forever free→ Telegram + Email connectors→ Basic keyword Decrees→ No Advisor→ Community accessSOVEREIGN TIER · €4.90/month→ All connectors including WhatsApp→ Full Decree system→ Advisor (all levels)→ SMS delivery included (fair use)→ Isolated bridge instance per user→ Priority community support
```

Cloud Privacy Commitment

- Each user gets an isolated bridge instance, so messages are never shared across users
- Messages never stored, processed in memory only
- Advisor model stored encrypted, accessible only to you
- No advertising, ever
- No data sold, ever
- Annual transparency report published openly

Open Source Governance

License: AGPL-3.0. Anyone can run it, modify it, and must keep modifications open source. Commercial use requires contribution back. Sovereign LLC cannot relicense it closed.

Entity	Role
Sovereign Foundation (non-profit)	Owns trademark, maintains core repository, publishes community Decree library, runs annual transparency report
Sovereign LLC (for-profit, owned by foundation)	Runs managed cloud, funds development from cloud revenue, cannot contradict foundation charter

The Community Platform

sovereign.community is a self-hosted Discourse forum. No algorithms, chronological only. No engagement metrics shown to users. No notification dark patterns. The community platform practices what Sovereign preaches.

PART IV: TECHNOLOGY STACK

Component	Technology	Rationale
Core engine	Python + FastAPI	Readable, fast, strong ecosystem
Platform connectors	Node.js + Express	mautrix bridges are Go; connectors in Node
WhatsApp bridge	mautrix-whatsapp (Go)	Lower ban risk than Baileys for personal use
Telegram bridge	mautrix-telegram (Go)	Official API support
Database (Synapse)	PostgreSQL	Synapse requirement
Database (Sovereign)	SQLite	Lightweight for single-user instances
AI / Advisor	Ollama (local LLM)	Never cloud inference, behavioral data stays local
SMS gateway	Twilio API / gammu (GSM modem)	Cloud tier vs full sovereignty option
Interface	React + Vite	Minimal, calm design system
Deployment	Docker Compose	Single command, reproducible
Reverse proxy	Nginx	Standard, well-documented
Community	Discourse (self-hosted)	Chronological, no algorithm
License	AGPL-3.0	Community-protected forever

PART V: LAUNCH SEQUENCE

Not a product hunt launch. Not a viral marketing campaign. A quiet, honest release that matches the philosophy.

Phase	When	What
Phase 0. Founder	Now	You, as the first user. Document everything: setup, friction, surprises, the first week of held messages. This becomes Sovereign's founding story.
Phase 1. Private Beta	Month 3-4	20 to 30 people from your network. No press. No hype. Honest testers who feel the problem. Collect what breaks, what's missing, what moves them.
Phase 2. Community Release	Month 6	Open source repository published. Manifesto published. Self-hosted path fully documented. sovereign.community opens. No managed cloud yet, community first.
Phase 3. Managed Cloud	Month 9-12	Cloud tier opens for people who found Sovereign through the community but can't self-host. Funded entirely by first subscribers. No venture capital. No press release.
Phase 4. Movement	Ongoing	Community contributes Decrees. Advisor library grows. Hardware guides multiply. Translations appear. Sovereign becomes a word people use.

PART VI: KEY DECISIONS LOG

Every significant design decision made during specification, with rationale. To be consulted when future choices arise that might contradict the foundation.

Decision	Choice Made	Rationale
WhatsApp connector	mautrix-whatsapp over Baileys	Lower ban risk for personal human-paced use. Baileys emulates bot behavior; mautrix emulates web client behavior.
AI inference	Local Ollama over cloud API	Behavioral patterns never leave the user's machine. Not even to Sovereign's servers.
Pricing model	Open source + €4.90/month managed	Open source for trust and community. Honest fee to cover hosting. No VC, no growth hacking.
Interface access	Browser only, never an App Store app	Friction is a feature. Governance should require intention.
Groups default	All group messages held by default	No group message has ever been genuinely urgent. Users can override.
Message storage	Never stored, processed in memory only	Privacy is non-negotiable. Processing and delivery leave no trace.
Advisor pooling	Per-user only, never pooled	This is the inverse of how every major platform operates. Your patterns protect you only.
Council size	Soft limit of 10 with friction prompt	An unlimited VIP list is no VIP list. Sovereign respects autonomy but nudges toward discipline.
Governance structure	Non-profit foundation + for-profit LLC	Proven model (Mozilla, WordPress, Signal). Aligns incentives permanently.
Target audience	Over-connected, not under-connected	Sovereign is not for people starved of connection. It is for people drowning in it. Humanitarian workers and isolated individuals are explicitly not the audience.

CLOSING NOTE

This document was produced in a single design session, philosophy first and technology second. That order was intentional and must be preserved as Sovereign grows.

Every technical decision made in this specification traces back to the manifesto. When future decisions are difficult, return here: does this choice serve the right to be unreachable? If not, cut it.

Sovereign began with a feeling. A hand reaching for a phone that shouldn't have. A meal interrupted by nothing urgent. A morning owned by someone else's algorithm.

It ends, for now, with a complete architecture, a philosophy, a vocabulary, a business model, and a founder who will be its first user.

This is not for those who hunger for connection. It is for those who have forgotten what it feels like to be without it.

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sovereign.community · github.com/sovereign-stack/sovereign